

The People

A qualitative companion to the trajectories study: who they were, what they knew, and the cases worth reading one at a time

23 August 2026

Abstract

The main paper reduces 235 careers to a single number. This companion puts the people back. It carries a profile row for every person in the study — highest completed degree, field, institution, nationality, sex and area of expertise — a chapter of descriptive statistics over those fields, and a chapter of individual cases chosen because their numbers argue with the median.

Degree and institution facts were lifted from the sourced notes already attached to each row in `data/anchors.csv` (86% of rows) and researched fresh only where those notes were silent. *unknown* appears where nothing was found; the study does not guess, and 16 people have no sourced credential at all.

The same caveat governs every number here. These are people who already succeeded. The sample has no denominator, so nothing in this document is a rate or a forecast — see the main paper’s glossary.

1 The sample in numbers

All figures below cover the 201 included people. Where a row is marked *commercial*, it covers only the 121 whose hit is \$10M-constant revenue; the rest reached an equivalent threshold such as a major prize or a \$100M fund.

1.1 Highest completed degree

Degree	People	Share
Bachelors	63	31%
Masters	47	23%
PhD	42	21%
HighSchool	21	10%
unknown	14	7%
MD	6	3%
None	4	2%
Associate	2	1%
JD	2	1%

Just over half the sample stopped at a bachelor's degree or below. That is the single most counter-intuitive number in this table for anyone assuming credentials gate outlier outcomes.

1.2 Age at first hit, by degree (commercial hits only)

Degree	n	Median age	Venture clock
PhD	11	44.0	4.5 yr
MD	3	36.0	1.0 yr
Masters	31	33.8	4.0 yr
Bachelors	45	31.0	4.0 yr
HighSchool	15	28.5	4.0 yr
None	4	33.2	11.0 yr

1.3 Field of the highest degree

Field	People
unknown	52
Computer Science	17
Electrical Engineering	13
Business Administration	9
Business	8
Medicine	7
Mathematics	6
Physics	5
Chemistry	4
Electrical Engineering and Computer Science	4
Finance	3
Commerce	3

1.4 Where they were educated

Institution	People
Stanford University	12
Harvard Business School	5
Cornell University	4
Harvard University	4
University of California, Berkeley	4
University of Cambridge	3
Massachusetts Institute of Technology	3
MIT	3
University of Waterloo	3
Yale University	3

The concentration is real but far weaker than folklore suggests: no institution accounts for more than a small fraction, and the long tail of one-appearance schools is the bulk of the sample.

1.5 Nationality and sex

Country	People
US	94
CN	16
GB	11
IN	11
DE	7
FR	6
KR	5
JP	5
CA	5
NG	3

Sex: M 150 (75%), F 51 (25%). These are recorded covariates, never selection criteria — the sole standard for entry was the money threshold.

1.6 Area of expertise, most common

Expertise	People
venture capital	12
e-commerce	4
literary fiction	3
seed-stage venture capital	3
shapewear	2
feature film directing	2
web search	2
electronic health records	2
payments processing	2
generic pharmaceuticals	2
ride-hailing	2
handheld computing	2
narrative film	2
programming languages	2

2 Some interesting cases

These are not the most famous people in the sample. They are the ones whose numbers argue with the median, and each is here because it teaches something the pooled figure hides.

The ones who took a lifetime

John Hopfield — neural networks, PhD, hit at **91**. Sixty-six years from finishing his doctorate to the 2024 Nobel. The associative memory network he described in 1982 was recognised four decades later, when hardware finally made the idea matter. His row is the single longest clock in the study and a clean demonstration that recognition dates the world’s readiness, not the work.

Tu Youyou — artemisinin, bachelor’s degree, hit at **85**. She isolated the compound in the early 1970s inside a classified military programme, without a doctorate, a postdoc, or foreign training. The Nobel came in 2015. Her clock is 60 years and every one of them is an artifact of who was allowed to be recognised and when.

Rita Levi-Montalcini — nerve growth factor, MD, hit at 77. Began the work in a bedroom laboratory in wartime Italy after racial laws barred her from academic posts. The study cannot represent what that start cost, only that the interval was 50 years.

The ones who took almost no time

Katrina Lake — apparel e-commerce, hit **1.5 years** after her MBA, at 30. The shortest education-to-hit clock in the commercial data. She had worked in retail analytics and venture capital first; the MBA sat late in a career already pointed at the problem, which is exactly why the clock reads short. A reminder that a short clock often means the anchor moved, not that the work was quick.

Austin Russell — lidar, no degree, hit at **20**. Left Stanford on a Thiel Fellowship having started the company at 17. He and Aadit Palicha (quick commerce, hit at 20) are the two youngest commercial crossings in the study, and both skipped the credential entirely rather than finishing it fast.

Frank Wang — consumer drones, hit 1.5 years out of his master’s at 32. The company was founded in his dormitory; the degree and the venture overlap rather than sequence. Several of the fastest clocks in this study share that shape, and it is worth noticing that “fast” usually means *concurrent*, not *efficient*.

The ones with no degree at all

Eighteen people crossed \$10M-constant with a high-school credential or less. The set is more varied than the stereotype:

Zhou Qunfei left school at 16 to work in a watch-lens factory in Shenzhen and crossed at 34 in cover-glass manufacturing — a capital-intensive industrial business, not a software one. **Amancio Ortega** began as a shirt shop errand boy and crossed at 32. **Robert Kuok** (sugar trading, 37) and

Martua Sitorus (palm oil, 32) both built commodity trading houses. **Diane Hendricks** crossed at 37 in building-materials distribution after starting in custom home building.

The pattern worth extracting: the no-degree cohort is concentrated in *physical* businesses — manufacturing, distribution, trading, retail — where the barrier is operational competence and capital rather than credentialed knowledge. The famous college-dropout software founders are the minority of this group, not its archetype.

The career switchers

Sara Blakely sold fax machines door to door for seven years before founding a shapewear company with no apparel background whatsoever. Her row was recruited into the study precisely to stress the assumption that the pre-venture decade must be spent in-domain.

She is not an outlier. One in five of the winners entered their eventual field three or more years after finishing education, with a median detour of 4.5 years, and their median age at hit — 34.2 — is under two years behind those who went straight in. **The detour is survivable and common.** What the data does not show is any evidence that it *helps*.

The one whose date is a warning

Mark Zuckerberg's crossing is dated 2005, and the paper flags it as the weakest-supported figure in that wave. The 2005 revenue figure comes from a single trade-press sentence quoting an S-1 that does not itself disclose anything before 2007; the margin above the bar is 48%, the narrowest in its batch. If that one sentence is wrong, the crossing moves to 2006.

It is included because the alternative — dropping every row whose evidence is thin — would bias the sample toward the well-documented, which is the very failure mode the study spent the most effort fighting. It is called out here so that anyone quoting his row quotes the uncertainty with it.

The pair that changed the method

Donna Dubinsky and **Jeff Hawkins** both date to 1995 at Palm Computing. Two people, one crossing. Because the bootstrap treats every row as an independent draw, correlated rows narrow the confidence interval without adding information — the estimate looks more precise than the evidence supports.

Finding them led to a rule change mid-study: one row per hit *event*, entity plus year, not per person. On its first use the rule rejected five candidates, including a brother pair who founded one pharmaceutical company and two co-holders of a single Nobel year. Both Palm rows were kept because they sit outside the headline set and cannot affect the reported interval — and because dropping one would have required inventing a rule for choosing between a founder and the CEO who built it, which correlates with sex in this sample.

The youngest crossings are not entrepreneurs

Billie Eilish crossed at **15** and **Olivia Dean** at **20** — both on the audience criterion rather than revenue. Creative careers can reach a million-person audience before the person is old enough to sign a contract alone, and no business in this dataset does anything comparable.

If you are drawn to the very young hits in this study, note which criterion they fired on. The youngest *commercial* crossings are 20, and there are two of them out of 121.

3 The catalogue

One row per person, all 235, in the order they entered the study. **Excl.** marks a row excluded from the analysis — almost always because the crossing year could not be sourced, which is a documentation failure and not a judgement about the person. *unk* means the fact was not found; the study never guesses.

Name	Company / entity	en-	Degree	Field	Institution	Nat	Sex	Expertise
Sara Blakely	Spanx		Bachelor	Communication	Florida State University	US	F	shapewear
Katalin Kariko	Breakthrough Prize in Life Sciences		PhD	Biochemistry	University of Szeged	US	F	mRNA vaccines
Tadashi Yanai (<i>excl.</i>)	Fast Retailing		Bachelor	Economics and Political Science	Waseda University	JP	M	apparel retail
Gordon Moore	Fairchild conductor	Semi-	PhD	Chemistry	California Institute of Technology	US	M	semiconductors
Bong Joon-ho	Memories of Murder		Bachelor	Sociology	Yonsei University	KR	M	feature film directing
Mary Meeker	Institutional Investor All-America Research Team (Internet)		Master	Finance	Cornell University	US	F	internet equity research
Kevin Systrom	Instagram		Bachelor	Management Science and Engineering	Stanford University	US	M	photo sharing
Robin Li	Baidu		Master	Computer Science	University at Buffalo	CN	M	web search

Name	Company / entity		Degree	Field	Institution	Nat	Sex	Expertise
Daniel Ek	Spotify		High sch.	Information Technology	IT-Gymnasiet	SE	M	music streaming
Zhang Yin	America Nam	Chung	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	CN	F	recovered-paper export
Stephanie Shirley	Freelance International	Pro-grammers / F	Bachelor	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	GB	F	freelance programming
Judy Faulkner	Epic Systems		Master	Computer Sciences	University of Wisconsin-Madison	US	F	electronic health records
Dietmar Hopp	SAP		Master	Telecommunications Engineering	TH Karlsruhe	DE	M	enterprise software
Kazuhiko Nishi (<i>excl.</i>)	ASCII		PhD	<i>unk</i>	Kogakuin University	JP	M	personal-computer publishing
Sandra Kurtzig (<i>excl.</i>)	ASK Systems	Computer	Master	Aeronautical Engineering	Stanford University	US	F	manufacturing software
Shola Akinlade	Paystack		Bachelor	Computer Science	Babcock University	NG	M	payments processing
Shigenobu Nagamori	Nidec (Nihon Densan)		Bachelor	Electrical Engineering	Institute of Vocational Training	JP	M	precision motors
Morris Chang	TSMC		PhD	Electrical Engineering	Stanford University	TW	M	semiconductor foundries
Zhou Qunfei	Lens Technology		none	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	CN	F	cover-glass manufacturing
An Wang	Wang Laboratories	Laborato-ries	PhD	Applied Physics	Harvard University	US	M	computer systems
Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw (<i>excl.</i>)	Biocon		Master	Brewing	Ballarat College / University of Melbourne	IN	F	industrial enzymes
Thomas Struengmann	Hexal		<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	University of Augsburg	DE	M	generic pharmaceuticals
Zhong Huijuan (<i>excl.</i>)	Hansoh Pharmaceutical (Jiangsu Hansoh / Haosen)	Phar-maceutical	Master	<i>unk</i>	Nanjing University	CN	F	oncology pharmaceuticals
Alfred Mann (<i>excl.</i>)	Pacesetter Systems	Sys-tems	Master	Physics	UCLA	US	M	implantable medical devices

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Karsanbhai Patel	Nirma	Bachelor	Chemistry	<i>unk</i>	IN	M	detergent manufacturing
Anita Roddick	The Body Shop	<i>unk</i>	Teaching	Newton Park College of Education	GB	F	natural cosmetics retail
Kim Sung-joo (<i>excl.</i>)	Sungjoo International	Master	Business Ethics and Economics	Harvard University	KR	F	luxury brand licensing
Rita Levi-Montalcini	Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine	MD	Medicine	University of Turin Medical School	IT	F	nerve growth factor
Jean-Marie Lehn	Nobel Prize in Chemistry	PhD	Chemistry	University of Strasbourg	FR	M	supramolecular chemistry
Tu Youyou	Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine	Bachelor	Pharmacology	Beijing Medical College	CN	F	artemisinin
Sonali De Rycker	Accel London IV	Master	Business	Harvard Business School	GB	F	venture capital
Raghuram Rajan (<i>excl.</i>)	<i>unk</i>	PhD	Finance	MIT Sloan	US	M	financial economics
Toni Morrison	Song of Solomon	Master	American Literature	Cornell University	US	F	literary fiction
Youssou N'Dour	"7 Seconds" (with Neneh Cherry)	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	SN	M	mbalax
Ryan Petersen	Flexport	Master	Business	Columbia Business School	US	M	freight forwarding
Melanie Perkins	Canva	High sch.	<i>unk</i>	Sacred Heart College	AU	F	graphic design software
Michelle Zatlyn	Cloudflare	Master	Business	Harvard Business School	US	F	content delivery networks
Rana el Kaliouby	Affectiva	PhD	Computer Science	University of Cambridge	US	F	affective computing
Nadiem Makarim	Gojek	Master	Business	Harvard Business School	ID	M	ride-hailing
Olugbenga Agboola	Flutterwave	Master	Business	MIT Sloan School of Management	NG	M	payments processing

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Kunal Bahl	Jasper Infotech (MoneySaver / Snapdeal)		Bachelor	Management and Technology	University of Pennsylvania	IN	M	e-commerce
Enric Asunción	Wallbox		Master	Engineering	Universitat Politècnica de Catalunya	ES	M	EV charging hardware
Federico Faggin	Zilog		Master	Physics	University of Padua	US	M	microprocessors
David Sun	Camintonn Corporation	Cor-	Bachelor	Electrical Engineering	Tatung University	US	M	computer memory
Min Kao	Garmin		PhD	Electrical Engineering	University of Tennessee	US	M	GPS navigation
Katrina Lake	Stitch Fix		Master	Business	Harvard Business School	US	F	apparel e-commerce
Aliko Dangote (<i>excl.</i>)	Dangote Group		Bachelor	Business Administration	Al-Azhar University	NG	M	cement manufacturing
James Dyson	Dyson		<i>unk</i>	Industrial Design	Royal College of Art	GB	M	cyclonic vacuum design
Reshma Sohoni	Seedcamp IV	Fund	Master	Business	INSEAD	GB	F	seed-stage venture capital
Hemant Taneja	General Catalyst Group VI		Master	Electrical Engineering and Computer Science	Massachusetts Institute of Technology	US	M	growth-stage venture capital
Aileen Lee	Cowboy Ventures III		Master	Business	Harvard Business School	US	F	seed-stage venture capital
Kendrick Lamar	good kid, m.A.A.d city	kid, High sch.		<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	US	M	West Coast hip-hop
Tems	Essence (with Wizkid)	(with <i>unk</i>)	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	NG	F	alté R&B
Taika Waititi	Hunt for the Wilderpeople		Bachelor	Theatre	Victoria University of Wellington	NZ	M	feature film directing
Donna Strickland	Nobel Prize in Physics		PhD	Optics	University of Rochester	CA	F	chirped pulse amplification
Yoshua Bengio	ACM A.M. Turing Award		PhD	Computer Science	McGill University	CA	M	deep neural networks
Maryam Mirzakhani	Fields Medal		PhD	Mathematics	Harvard University	US	F	hyperbolic geometry

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Özlem Türeci	Ganymed Pharmaceuticals	Phar-	MD	Medicine	Saarland University	DE	F	cancer immunotherapy
Cyrus Poonawalla (<i>excl.</i>)	Serum Institute of India	Institute	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	Brihan Maharashtra College of Commerce	IN	M	vaccine manufacturing
Gianluigi Aponte	Mediterranean Shipping Company	Com-	High sch.	Nautical studies	Istituto Tecnico Nautico Statale Nino Bixio	CH	M	container shipping
William Ding	NetEase		Bachelor	Communication Technology	University of Electronic Science and Technology of China	CN	M	online games
Shiv Nadar	HCL (Hindustan Computers Limited)	Lim-	Bachelor	Electrical Engineering	PSG College of Technology	IN	M	computer hardware
Harshil Mathur	Razorpay		Bachelor	<i>unk</i>	IIT Roorkee	IN	M	digital payments
Sid Sijbrandij	GitLab		Master	Management Science	University of Twente	NL	M	software collaboration
Chris Wanstrath	GitHub		High sch.	<i>unk</i>	St. Xavier High School	US	M	code hosting
Jeff Lawson	Twilio		Bachelor	Computer Science	University of Michigan	US	M	communications APIs
Robin Zeng	Amperex Technology Limited (ATL)	Tech-	PhD	Physics	Chinese Academy of Sciences	HK	M	lithium-ion batteries
Robert Pera	Ubiquiti Networks	Net-	Master	<i>unk</i>	UC San Diego	US	M	wireless networking
Terry Gou	Hon Hai (Foxconn)	(Fox-	Bachelor	<i>unk</i>	Taipei University of Marine Technology	TW	M	electronics manufacturing
Donna Dubinsky	Palm Computing	Computing	Master	Business Administration	Harvard	US	F	handheld computing
Radhakishan Damani	Avenue Supermarts (DMart)	Super-	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	IN	M	supermarket retail

Name	Company / entity	en-	Degree	Field	Institution	Nat	Sex	Expertise
Zhong Shanshan	Nongfu Spring		Assoc.	Chinese Language and Literature	Zhejiang Radio and Television University	CN	M	bottled water
He Xiangjian	Midea		none	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	CN	M	home appliances
Dilip Shanghvi	Sun Pharmaceutical Industries		Bachelor	Commerce	University of Calcutta	IN	M	generic pharmaceuticals
Jason Kelly	Ginkgo Bioworks		PhD	Biological Engineering	MIT	US	M	synthetic biology
Trevor Martin (<i>excl.</i>)	Mammoth Biosciences		PhD	<i>unk</i>	Stanford University	US	M	CRISPR diagnostics
Luciana Lixandru	Accel London VI		Bachelor	Mathematics and Economics	Georgetown	RO	F	venture capital
Eileen Burbidge (<i>excl.</i>)	Passion Capital		Bachelor	Computer Science	University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign	GB	F	venture capital
Johan Brenner	Creandum V		Master	<i>unk</i>	Stockholm School of Economics	SE	M	venture capital
Emmanuelle Charpentier	Nobel Prize in Chemistry		PhD	<i>unk</i>	Pierre and Marie Curie University	FR	F	CRISPR gene editing
Simon Brendle	Breakthrough Prize in Mathematics		PhD	<i>unk</i>	University of Tübingen	DE	M	geometric analysis
Maryna Viazovska	Via Fields Medal		PhD	Mathematics	University of Bonn	UA	F	sphere packing
Chloé Zhao	Nomadland		Master	Film	New York University	US	F	narrative film
Viet Thanh Nguyen	The Sympathizer		PhD	English	UC Berkeley	US	M	literary fiction
Wang Wei (<i>excl.</i>)	SF Express		High sch.	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	CN	M	express logistics
Vidit Aatrey	Meesho		Bachelor	Electrical Engineering	IIT Delhi	IN	M	social commerce
Aadit Palicha	Zepto		High sch.	<i>unk</i>	GEMS Modern Academy	IN	M	quick commerce

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Wade Foster	Zapier	Master	Business Administration	University of Missouri	US	M	workflow automation
Wei Deng	Clipboard Health	JD	Law	Yale	US	F	healthcare staffing
Eugenio Pace	Auth0	Master	Computer Science	Instituto Tecnológico de Buenos Aires	AR	M	identity management
Karim Beguir	InstaDeep	Master	<i>unk</i>	New York University	TN	M	deep learning
Mudassir Sheikha	Careem	Master	Computer Science	Stanford University	AE	M	ride-hailing
Sophie Wilson	Element 14	Bachelor	<i>unk</i>	University of Cambridge	GB	F	microprocessor design
Jeff Hawkins	Palm Computing	Bachelor	Electrical Engineering	Cornell	US	M	handheld computing
Frank Wang	DJI	Master	<i>unk</i>	Hong Kong University of Science and Technology	CN	M	consumer drones
Lei Jun	Joyo.com	Bachelor	Computer Science	Wuhan University	CN	M	e-commerce
Chip Wilson (<i>excl.</i>)	Westbeach	Bachelor	Economics	University of Calgary	CA	M	snowboard apparel
Ismael Belkhatat (<i>excl.</i>)	Chari	Master	Business Administration	Cornell University	MA	M	B2B grocery commerce
Colson Whitehead	The Underground Railroad	Bachelor	<i>unk</i>	Harvard	US	M	literary fiction
Jane Campion	The Piano	Bachelor	Anthropology	Victoria University of Wellington	NZ	F	narrative film
Angélique Kidjo	Arc de Triomphe WWI centenary performance	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	BJ	F	Afropop
Alain Aspect	Nobel Prize in Physics	PhD	<i>unk</i>	Université Paris-Sud	FR	M	quantum optics
Carolyn Bertozzi	Nobel Prize in Chemistry	PhD	Chemistry	UC Berkeley	US	F	bioorthogonal chemistry
Dennis Gaitsgory	Breakthrough Prize in Mathematics	PhD	<i>unk</i>	Tel Aviv University	DE	M	geometric Langlands

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Leonard Schleifer	Regeneron	MD	Medicine	University of Virginia	US	M	biologic drugs
Alice Zhang	Verge Genomics	Bachelor	Molecular Biology	Princeton	US	F	AI drug discovery
Laurel Bowden	Greylock Israel II	Master	Business Administration	INSEAD	ZA	F	venture capital
Ondrej Bartos	Credo Stage 3	Master	Finance and Accounting	Prague University of Economics and Business	CZ	M	venture capital
John Fredriksen (excl.)	<i>unk</i>	none	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	CY	M	tanker shipping
Betsie Larkin	Honeylove	Bachelor	Mathematics	Boston University	US	F	shapewear
Bom Kim	Coupang	Bachelor	<i>unk</i>	Harvard College	KR	M	e-commerce
James Burkhardt	Odeko	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	US	M	cafe supply operations
Michael Carvin (excl.)	<i>unk</i>	Bachelor	<i>unk</i>	Princeton	US	M	personal finance software
Sajith Wickramasekara (excl.)	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	US	M	life science software
Yoshikazu Tanaka	GREE, Inc.	Bachelor	Political Economy	Nihon University	JP	M	social gaming
Kosuke Sogo	AnyMind Group (AdAsia Holdings)	Bachelor	Commerce	Nihon University	JP	M	influencer marketing
Wang Chuanfu	BYD Company (Shenzhen BYD Battery)	Master	<i>unk</i>	Beijing Non-Ferrous Metal General Research Institute	CN	M	rechargeable batteries
Diane Hendricks	ABC Supply	High sch.	<i>unk</i>	Osseo-Fairchild High School	US	F	building materials distribution
Kishore Biyani (excl.)	<i>unk</i>	Bachelor	<i>unk</i>	Bombay University	IN	M	mass retail

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Claudia Goldin		Nobel Prize in Economic Sciences		PhD	Economics	University of Chicago	US	F	labor economics	eco-
Qin Yinglin (excl.)		unk		Bachelor	Animal Husbandry	Henan Agricultural University	CN	M	pig breeding	
Austin Russell		Luminar Technologies	Tech-	High sch.	unk	St. Margaret's Episcopal School	US	M	lidar	
Rodney Brooks		iRobot Corporation (IS Robotics, Inc.)		PhD	Computer Science	Stanford University	AU	M	robotics	
Patrick Soon-Shiong		American Pharmaceutical Partners, Inc.	Phar-	MD	Medicine	University of the Witwatersrand	US	M	injectable pharmaceuticals	
Xu Hang		Shenzhen Mindray Bio-Medical Electronics Co., Ltd. (Mindray Medical International)	Min-	Master	Biomedical Engineering	Tsinghua University	CN	M	medical devices	
Sun Piaoyang (excl.)		unk		Bachelor	Pharmaceutical Chemistry	China Pharmaceutical University	CN	M	pharmaceuticals	
Zhu Gongshan		Taichang Xiexin Thermal Power Co., Ltd.	Poly Thermal	Assoc.	Electrical Automation	Nanjing Electric Power College	CN	M	cogeneration	
Barbara Liskov		ACM A.M. Turing Award		PhD	Computer Science	Stanford University	US	F	programming languages	
Caucher Birkar		Fields Medal		PhD	Algebraic Geometry	University of Nottingham	GB	M	birational geometry	
Kirsten Green		Forerunner Partners III, L.P.	Part-	Bachelor	Business Economics	UCLA	US	F	consumer venture capital	
Ann Miura-Ko		Floodgate III, L.P.	Fund	PhD	Information Security	Stanford University	US	F	seed-stage venture capital	
Arooj Aftab (excl.)		Mohabbat (Vulture Prince)	(Vul-	Bachelor	Music Production and Engineering	Berklee College of Music	PK	F	jazz vocals	
Domee Shi		Bao		Bachelor	Animation	Sheridan College	CA	F	animation direction	

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Robert Kuok	Malayan Manufacturing Co. Bhd.	Sugar	High sch.	<i>unk</i>	Raffles Institution	MY	M	sugar trading
Martua Sitorus	Wilmar Pte Ltd / Wilmar Group	Trading	High sch.	<i>unk</i>	SMA Mulia	Budi ID	M	palm oil trading
Tracy Young	PlanGrid		Bachelor	Construction Management	Sacramento State	US	F	construction software
Josh Reeves	Gusto (ZenPayroll)		Master	Electrical Engineering	Stanford University	US	M	payroll software
Spenser Skates	Amplitude, Inc.		Bachelor	Biological Engineering	MIT	US	M	product analytics
Apoorva Mehta	Instacart (Maplebear Inc.)		Bachelor	Electrical Engineering	University of Waterloo	CA	M	grocery delivery
Drew Durbin	Sendwave (Chime Inc.)		Bachelor	<i>unk</i>	Brown University	US	M	mobile remittances
Yoshi Yokokawa	Alpaca (AlpacaDB, Inc.)		Bachelor	Policy Management	Keio University	JP	M	brokerage infrastructure
David Gausebeck	Matterport, Inc.		Bachelor	Computer Science	University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign	US	M	3D spatial capture
Veronica Pascual Boe	ASTI Robotics	Mobile	Master	Business Administration	College des Ingenieurs	ES	F	mobile robotics
Andrea Pizarulli	Civitanavi Systems	Sys-	Bachelor	Electronic Engineering	Universita Politecnica delle Marche	IT	M	inertial navigation
Raycho Raychev	EnduroSat		Master	Space Management	International Space University	BG	M	small satellites
Mateo Marietti (<i>excl.</i>)	POP (Sushi Pop)		Bachelor	Business Economics	Universidad Torcuato Di Tella	AR	M	sushi restaurants
Tuan Ee Loi	Farm Fresh (The Holstein Milk Company)	(The Milk)	High sch.	<i>unk</i>	Sekolah Menengah Jenis Kebangsaan Ayer Tawar	MY	M	fresh milk

Name	Company / entity	Degree	Field	Institution	Nat	Sex	Expertise
Maria Madero	Jose Ben & Frank	Bachelor	Fashion and Textile Design	CENTRO de Diseno, Cine y Television	MX	F	eyewear
Gili Raanan	Cyberstarts Venture Fund II, L.P.	Master	Business Administration	Recanati School of the Tel Aviv University	IL	M	cybersecurity venture capital
Neil Shen	Sequoia Capital China (first fund 2005 / China II 2007)	Master	Management	Yale School of Management	CN	M	venture capital
Martin Mignot	Index Ventures IX (Jersey), L.P.	Master	Finance	Sciences Po	FR	M	venture capital
Daniel Kraus (excl.)	Whalefall (2023) / Angel Down (2025) / The Shape of Water (2018)	Master	Library and Information Science	University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign	US	M	fiction writing
Bad Bunny	Diles (2016 single/video)	High sch.	unk	unk	PR	M	Latin trap
Maggie Kang	KPop Demon Hunters (2025)	Bachelor	Animation	Sheridan College	KR	F	animation
Omar M. Yaghi	Nobel Prize in Chemistry	PhD	Inorganic Chemistry	University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign	US	M	metal-organic frameworks
Shimon Sakauchi	Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine	PhD	Medicine	Kyoto University	JP	M	regulatory T cells
Michel H. Devoret	Nobel Prize in Physics	PhD	Quantum Condensed-Matter Physics	Universite Paris-Sud	FR	M	superconducting circuits
Jason Borschow (excl.)	Abarca Health	Bachelor	Economics	Harvard University	PR	M	pharmacy benefits
Hoang Nguyen	Buymed (thuocsi.vn)	Bachelor	unk	Foreign Trade University	VN	M	pharmaceutical e-commerce
Jay McHarg (excl.)	AeroSafe Global (American Aero-gel Corporation)	Master	Business Administration	Babson College	US	M	cold-chain packaging

Name	Company / entity	en-	Degree	Field	Institution	Nat	Sex	Expertise
Amancio Ortega	Confecciones GOA (later Inditex)		none	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	ES	M	fast fashion
Reinhold Wuerth	Adolf Wuerth KG (Wuerth Group)		none	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	DE	M	industrial fasteners
Eddy Lu	GOAT		Bachelor	<i>unk</i>	University of California, Berkeley	US	M	sneaker resale
Ken Olsen	Digital Equipment Corporation		Master	Electrical Engineering	MIT	US	M	minicomputers
Steve Wozniak	Apple Computer, Inc.		Bachelor	Electrical Engineering and Computer Science	University of California, Berkeley	US	M	personal computers
Gene Amdahl	Amdahl Corporation		PhD	Theoretical Physics	University of Wisconsin-Madison	US	M	mainframe computers
Konrad Zuse	Zuse KG		Master	Civil Engineering	TH Berlin-Charlottenburg	DE	M	computers
Thomas Frist Jr.	Hospital Corporation of America		MD	Medicine	Washington University School of Medicine	US	M	hospital chains
Chung Yong-ji	Caregen Co., Ltd.		PhD	Molecular Biology	Cornell University	KR	M	biomimetic peptides
Alyson Frieden-sohn (<i>excl.</i>)	<i>unk</i>		Bachelor	Global Environmental Change and Sustainability	Johns Hopkins University	US	F	workplace mental health
Vinod Khosla	Kleiner Perkins Caufield & Byers VI		Master	Business Administration	Stanford University	US	M	venture capital
Eric Vishria	Benchmark Capital Partners IX, L.P.		Bachelor	Mathematical and Computational Science	Stanford University	US	M	venture capital

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Peter Thiel	Founders Fund	II	JD	Law	Stanford Law School	US	M	venture capital
Paul Thomas Anderson	Boogie Nights		High sch.	<i>unk</i>	Montclair College Preparatory School	US	M	film direction
SZA	Ctrl		High sch.	<i>unk</i>	Columbia High School	US	F	alternative R&B
Alan J. Perlis	ACM A.M. Turing Award		PhD	Mathematics	Massachusetts Institute of Technology	US	M	programming languages
Maurice Wilkes	V. ACM A.M. Turing Award		PhD	Physics	University of Cambridge	GB	M	stored-program computers
Lars Ahlfors	Valerian Fields Medal		PhD	Mathematics	University of Helsinki	FI	M	complex analysis
Zach Sims	Codecademy (Ryzac, Inc.)		High sch.	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	US	M	online coding education
Larry Page	Google Inc.		Master	Computer Science	Stanford University	US	M	web search
Ilya Volodarsky	Segment (Segment.io, Inc.)		High sch.	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	US	M	customer data infrastructure
Jeff Bezos	Amazon.com, Inc.		Bachelor	Electrical Engineering and Computer Science	Princeton University	US	M	e-commerce
Neal O'Mara	HelloSign Projects, Inc., d/b/a HelloSign	(JN)	Bachelor	Computer Science	Bucknell University	US	M	electronic signatures
Mark Zuckerberg	Facebook (Thefacebook, Inc.)		High sch.	<i>unk</i>	Phillips Exeter Academy	US	M	social networking
Gautam Adani	Adani Exports (now Adani Enterprises Ltd)		<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	IN	M	commodities trading
Mariya Nurislamova	Scentbird		Bachelor	Business Administration	Baruch College	US	F	fragrance subscription
Jim Ratcliffe	Inspec Group		Master	Finance	London Business School	GB	M	petrochemicals
Lakshmi Mittal	PT Ispat Indo		Bachelor	Commerce	St. Xavier's College	IN	M	steelmaking

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Carver Mead	Silicon Compilers Inc.		PhD	Electrical Engineering	California Institute of Technology	US	M	VLSI design
Stephen Lake	Thalmic Labs (North)		Bachelor	Mechatronics Engineering	University of Waterloo	CA	M	wearable computing
Aleksandr Konotopskyi	Ajax Systems		Bachelor	Telecommunications and Networks	NTU KPI	UA	M	wireless security systems
Luca Rossettini	D-Orbit		PhD	Advanced Space Propulsion	Politecnico di Milano	IT	M	satellite logistics
Murali Divi	Divi's Laboratories (founded as Divi's Research Centre)		PhD	Pharmaceutical Sciences	Kakatiya University	IN	M	generic API manufacturing
Zhu Yi (<i>excl.</i>)	Sichuan Biokin Pharmaceutical (founded 1996 as Sichuan Baili Pharmaceutical)		PhD	Management	Sichuan University	CN	M	oncology biologics
Elad Gil	Cosmic - Aleph 1, L.P.		PhD	Biology	Massachusetts Institute of Technology	US	M	solo venture investing
Trae Stephens	Founders IX, LP	Fund	Bachelor	Regional and Comparative Studies	Georgetown University	US	M	defense technology investing
Billie Eilish	Ocean Eyes (2015 SoundCloud single)		<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	US	F	pop music
Bess Wohl (<i>excl.</i>)	<i>unk</i>		Master	Acting	Yale University	US	F	playwriting
Jill Lepore	The New Yorker essays (from "People Power", 24 October 2005)		PhD	American Studies	Yale University	US	F	American history
Laurent Schwartz	Fields Medal		PhD	Mathematics	University of Strasbourg	FR	M	distribution theory
Ragnar Frisch	Nobel Prize in Economic Sciences		PhD	Mathematical Statistics	University of Oslo	NO	M	econometrics

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Edward Witten	Fields Medal	PhD	Physics	Princeton University	US	M	string theory
Victor Ho	Fivestars	Bachelor	Industrial Engineering	University of California, Berkeley	US	M	customer loyalty software
Larry Ellison	Oracle (founded as Software Development Laboratories)	High sch.	<i>unk</i>	South Shore High School	US	M	relational databases
Michael Nusi-mow	DrChrono	Bachelor	Computer Engineering	Stony Brook University	US	M	electronic health records
Zhang Yiming	ByteDance	Bachelor	Computer Engineering	Nankai University	CN	M	short-form video
Bo Lu	FutureAdvisor	Bachelor	Computer Science	University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign	US	M	robo-advisory
Ma Huateng	Tencent	Bachelor	Computer Science and Applied Engineering	Shenzhen University	CN	M	instant messaging
Huang Zheng	Ouku.com ()	Master	Computer Science	University of Wisconsin-Madison	CN	M	consumer electronics e-commerce
Fred Smith	Federal Express	Bachelor	Economics	Yale University	US	M	overnight air cargo
Alex Solomon	PagerDuty	Bachelor	Software Engineering	University of Waterloo	US	M	incident management
Pete Koomen	Optimizely	Master	Computer Science	University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign	US	M	A/B testing
Patrick Collison	Stripe	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	US	M	online payments
Bill Clerico	WePay	Bachelor	Computer Science	Boston College	US	M	integrated payments
Suhail Doshi	Mixpanel	High sch.	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	US	M	product analytics

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Brian Chesky	Airbnb		Bachelor	Industrial Design	Rhode Island School of Design	US	M	short-term lodging
Phil Knight	Blue Ribbon Sports (Nike)		Master	Business Administration	Stanford University	US	M	athletic footwear
François Pinault (excl.)	Pinault SA		none	unk	unk	FR	M	timber trading
Todd Graves (excl.)	Raising Cane's		Bachelor	Telecommunications	University of Georgia	US	M	chicken-finger restaurants
Ernest Garcia II	Ugly Duckling (later DriveTime)		unk	unk	unk	US	M	used-car lending
Allan Alcorn	Silicon Gaming		Bachelor	Electrical Engineering and Computer Science	University of California, Berkeley	US	M	casino gaming machines
Nolan Bushnell	Atari		Bachelor	Electrical Engineering	University of Utah	US	M	coin-op video games
Jensen Huang	NVIDIA		Master	Electrical Engineering	Stanford University	US	M	graphics processors
Robert Duggan	Computer Motion		High sch.	unk	unk	US	M	surgical robotics
Sulaiman Al Habib (excl.)	Dr. Sulaiman Al Habib Medical Services Group		MD	Medicine	King Saud University	SA	M	hospital operations
Seo Jung-jin	Celltrion		Master	Business Administration	Konkuk University	KR	M	biosimilars
Joel Mokyr	Nobel Prize in Economic Sciences		PhD	Economics	Yale University	US	M	economic history
John J. Hopfield	Nobel Prize in Physics		PhD	Physics	Cornell University	US	M	neural networks
Jean Bennett	Breakthrough Prize in Life Sciences		MD	Medicine	Harvard University	US	F	ocular gene therapy
Douglas Leone	Sequoia Capital VI		Master	Management	MIT Sloan School of Management	US	M	venture capital
Danny Rimer	Barksdale Group (1999 fund)		Bachelor	History and Literature	Harvard University	GB	M	venture capital

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Susie (<i>excl.</i>)	Neilson	Burned Chronicle	(SF series)	Master	Journalism	University of California, Berkeley	US	F	investigative journalism
Olivia Dean		Reason to Stay	(2018 single)	High sch.	Music	The BRIT School	GB	F	soul-pop music
Brad Jacobs		United Systems	Waste	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	US	M	solid waste management
Kjell Inge Rokke (<i>excl.</i>)		American Seafoods		none	<i>unk</i>	<i>unk</i>	NO	M	commercial fishing